CHHATTISGARH

TOO MANY HEADS, BUT SITUATION VACANT

Chhattisgarh Congress struggles to find a new chief to lead it to 2028 poll

By **Rahul Noronha**

THE 2023 POLL RESULT WAS A NASTY SURPRISE, so top Congress leaders are already at work for the next edition—though it's over two years away. Their first priority is to get good people in the posts that matter, especially that of state Congress president. The incumbent, former MP Deepak Baij, has put in over three years and a change of guard is in the offing. But consensus presently eludes the party—its eventual arrival not hastened by the fact that state in charge Sachin Pilot was replaced by Sukhdeo Bhagat.

Bhupesh Baghel was the state unit chief ahead of the 2018 elections, when the Congress ended a 15-year-long rule by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). It won a massive 68 out of the state's 90 seats, up from 39 in the previous 2013 election. What worked, especially, was Baghel's combination with leader of opposition T.S. Singhdeo—a Kurmi OBC face and a Kshatriya. Six months after Baghel became CM, he sought leave from the PCC chief's responsibilities and Mohan Markam, a tribal MLA, was brought in as a consensus man. Through the tumultuous years between 2019 and 2023, when Baghel and Singhdeo developed differences, Markam held the organisational fort for Baghel.

A DISMAL PHASE

In mid-2023, in a bid to soothe egos, the party elevated Singhdeo as deputy CM and replaced Markam with then Bastar MP Deepak Baij. A tough tenure lay in store for Baij—the Congress saw its rival bounce back from 15 seats in 2018 to 54 in the assembly poll soon after, take the Raipur bypoll in 2024, and sweep the 2025 urban body polls.



REARRANGING TOP BRASS L to R, PCC chief Deepak Baij, ex-Chhattisgarh CM Bhupesh Baghel and LoP T.S. Singhdeo in Ambikapur, Sept. 16

Takeaways

- **Consensus elusive on successor to Deepak Baij**
- **Singhdeo may be in the race, Baghel backing iffy**
- **Dilemma between OBC, ST face or plain capability**

Against that backdrop, the need for a new chief has been felt for months. During Pilot's oversight, sources say a consensus was reached on having a youthful OBC face. MLAs Umesh Patel, 42, and Devendra Yadav, 36, came up as names who could mark the generational change the party aspires to, while keeping social realities in view—Chhattisgarh, while known as a tribal state, has a 40-plus per cent OBC population.

But one group in the state unit is keen on an Adivasi face so that the party's sway among tribals—around 32 per cent of the electorate—returns to 2018 levels, when it swept the ST reserved seats in the north and south. Another group feels the choice should depend on popularity, not be dictated by caste or group. They say representational needs are already met by having Charandas Mahant, a veteran OBC face, as leader of opposition as well as Bhagat, a tribal from Jharkhand, as state in charge.

Sources say Singhdeo has thrown his hat in the ring; it's unclear whether Baghel will play ball. It's at the latter's insistence that a replacement has not been made yet, they add. Baghel is said to be expending much labour on having his nominee as state Youth Congress chief too. Even in its 2023 shock, the party had retained 42.23 per cent vote against the BJP's 46.27 per cent. So it sees itself in the fight, but procrastination could cost it—as in 2023, when the Baghel-Singhdeo rift was addressed too late. Insiders say it would be ideal to have the duo combine in a duet, a la 2018. Can that be achieved? ■